

interface, TechnoMail was a perfect fit for Bharati Vidyapeeth.

"We needed a single communication platform like TechnoMail to first make e-mail the primary mode of communication within the Bharati Vidyapeeth group. Further, it also provided a platform for employees to share knowledge, opinions and views via blogs and a centralised portal to address passive communication needs like the latest happenings in the group, news, internal circulars and notices," says Hange.

But why open source?

However, winning over Bharati Vidyapeeth wasn't easy for this open source enterprise mail solution vendor. Competing against Microsoft Exchange and IBM Lotus Notes, it was a severe battle for TechnoMail. "The robustness, scalability and cost-effectiveness of TechnoMail made us swing the open source way," says Hange.

Prior success stories in the education domain, too, tilted the balance towards TechnoMail. According to Sanjay Gurav, director, TechnoInfotech, "We have been working on the open source stack, which gave us a strong foothold in the education sector, bagging premium university clients in Maharashtra. In the University of Pune, we delivered a completely customised mailing solution with the assured scalability of 1,00,000 users. This gave Satyajit Hange the confidence to use our mailing solution."

"TechnoMail not only extended the open source advantages in terms of no user-based licensing, built-in spam control, virus filtering, a feature-rich collaborative user interface, but also offered an extremely flexible approach to building a centralised communication portal. It was a very cost-effective email infrastructure solution with value-added features like the integrated content management system and the recent customised SMS management application on the same server that addressed our bulk SMS needs, especially SMS in Marathi," says Hange.

Further, TechnoMail uses a complete stack of open source components with no user-based licensing, making it a scalable solution. "Bharati Vidyapeeth Group decided to go in for the HP Integrity High Availability server for TechnoMail. The entire solution runs on the HP Integrity rx2660 server. There was great synergy between TechnoMail and HP Integrity that ensured scalability, performance and investment protection," says Gurav.

Vivekanand Dhreshwar, country lead, Business Critical Systems for HP's ESSN Channel, says: "The Integrity servers provided best in class performance for Bharati Vidyapeeth's data-intensive workload. The servers use a chipset that delivers very high bandwidths for superior real time performance, and RAS features at every component such as the CPU, memory and I/O. Bharati Vidyapeeth will also benefit from the fact that they can run the TechnoMail application round-the-clock because the RAS features allow these servers to be used in a 24 x 7 x 365 environment."

"We had planned for 500 users to start with, while evaluating other options. But after implementing TechnoMail we stopped bothering about the number of incremental users we add to TechnoMail. Our growing user base is currently about 2,500 users, a number we reached in just five months,"

says Hange. The stability of the solution, the flexible approach, and the strong and responsive backend support further complemented Bharati Vidyapeeth's growth.

The housing of the TechnoMail solution at the Cyquator Internet Data Centre, a third-party hosting provider, in Pune, made the solution more robust. But why a third party hosting provider?

"It would have taken at least a year to establish a data centre with in-house expertise, managing the IT infrastructure 24x7 to achieve at least 99 per cent uptime of the communication portal. Cyquator, located in Pune, with a state-of-the-art infrastructure, assured us 24x7 uptime, physical security, power back-ups, support, firewalls, etc. The IDC gave us better bandwidth, faster access being in India, access from any of our locations through the Internet, no immediate need to have private network, security to our server through the firewall, besides 24x7 availability of support and access to our server," says Hange. Further, the data centre put a back-up server to ensure real-time data and configuration back-up, safeguarding the set-up in case of any failure.

Acceptance and maintenance

Though TechnoMail offered a centralised communication portal to Bharati Vidyapeeth, the TechnoMail route wasn't entirely smooth sailing. Acceptance by employees and solution maintenance were two hurdles the institute foresaw and they took concrete steps with assistance from TechnoInfotech to overcome these.

"We had training sessions with the TechnoInfotech team at all our campuses before launching the Communication Portal. For most users who were already using their personal or college mail IDs through the public mail and college domain, the shift was a cakewalk. Now, we have a helpdesk managed by the Technology Department to cater to user related queries," says Hange.

For support and services, TechnoInfotech too left no stone unturned. "We assured the organisation complete server management services along with TechnoMail, eliminating the need for a Linux expert in-house. The entire back-end support is available from TechnoInfotech through their centralised support team in Mumbai. The solution is strongly backed by an efficient support infrastructure and responsive team," says Gurav.

"At HP, Integrity is more than technology—it's a mission-critical infrastructure. The Integrity platform provides a unique combination of mission critical availability, virtualisation and scalability. TechnoMail was benchmarked on HP's integrity range of servers for this deployment. The Integrity rx 2660 server will help support the required number of users for Bharati Vidyapeeth," says Dhreshwar.

Looking ahead, Bharati Vidyapeeth hopes to use more of open source technology. "We have started evaluating open source solutions that will complement our growth plans," says Hange. With Bharati Vidyapeeth opening its gates to open source technology, more and more educational institutions may follow suit. 

By: Vanisha Joseph

The author loves to experiment and write for LINUX For You is her latest experiment. So, beware! Just a minute, she also happens to be a journalist during the day.